# Medicines Sick Day Rules

## Renal Department

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This leaflet provides advice about what do with certain medicines whilst suffering from a dehydrating illness. It is for people taking one or more of the following medications.

### 1. ACE inhibitors

A medicine for high blood pressure and heart problems
**Examples:** names ending in 'pril' such as Enalapril, Lisinopril, Perindopril, Ramipril

### 2. ARBs

A medicine for high blood pressure and heart problems
**Examples:** names ending in 'sartan' such as Candesartan, Irbesartan, Losartan, Valsartan (this includes Entresto)

### 3. NSAIDs

Anti-inflammatory painkillers
**Examples:** Ibuprofen, Naproxen, Diclofenac

### 4. Diuretics

Also called 'water pills' for too much fluid and high blood pressure
**Examples:** Bendroflumethiazide, Bumetanide, Furosemide, Indapamide, Metolazone, Spironolactone

### 5. Medicines for diabetes

**Examples:** Metformin, Empagliflozin

### 6. Medicines for diabetes, kidney disease and heart failure

**Examples:** names ending in 'flozin' such as Empagliflozin, Dapagliflozin

## What is dehydration and what causes it?

Dehydration happens when your body does not have as much water as it needs. Without enough water, your body cannot function properly.
You can have mild, moderate or severe dehydration, depending on how much fluid is missing from your body. Vomiting, diarrhoea or fever (high temperature, sweats, shaking) can make you dehydrated.

If you are sick once or have diarrhoea once, then you are unlikely to become dehydrated. Experiencing vomiting, diarrhea or fever **twice or more** in a day can make you dehydrated.

## Why should you be concerned about dehydration?

Taking certain medicines when you are dehydrated can cause illness that is more serious. These medicines include:

## ACE inhibitors, ARBs and NSAIDs

If you are dehydrated, these medicines can stop your kidneys working properly.

## Diuretics and Empagliflozin

These can make dehydration more likely.

## Metformin

If you are dehydrated and taking this medicine you are more likely to develop a serious side effect called lactic acidosis.

## What should you do with your medicines?

1. If you have a dehydrating illness, **stop taking the medicine(s) listed** in this leaflet.

2. However, it is **very important** that you **restart** your medicine once you have recovered from the illness. This is usually after 24 to 48 hours of eating and drinking normally. When you restart your medicine, just take them as normal; do not take extra for the doses you have missed.

## When should you contact a doctor, nurse, pharmacist or NHS 24?

1. Contact any of the above if your vomiting, diarrhoea or fever lasts longer than 48 hours.

2. If you have any doubts about re-starting your medicine, any of the above will be able to help you.

   NHS 24 is free to call on 111.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you a Medicines Sick Day Rules card to keep as an easy reminder.

Developed by Renal Consultant and reviewed by patients and staff

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This leaflet can be made available in other languages and formats on request